

Zscaler, Inc.

# Expect to Hear About Higher LT Margins, Multi-Product Story at Investor Day; But Will This Change Bear/Bull Mix?

We are attending ZS's investor day in NYC on Oct 6 where we expect it to reiterate its FY27 guide, take its LT margin target up to 25-30%, and talk about its aspiration toward \$10B in ARR. We could also hear about its multi-product story & how its pricing model is evolving beyond user-based ZIA/ZPA.

Four thoughts into Zscaler's Investor Day in New York City on October 6: (1) we expect ZS will reiterate its FY27 guide to reaffirm confidence in its forecast in light of its upcoming CRO transition, and could talk more about its aspiration of reaching \$10B in ARR, which we believe is a 5+ year path; (2) we think LT EBIT margins could go up to 25-30% as there is plenty of natural leverage in this business and security peers like PANW and CRWD are targeting margins in the high 20% to 30%+ range over the mid- to long-term; (3) outside of the financials, we think ZS will walk through how its business and pricing models are evolving, particularly as the business expands outside of user-based ZIA/ZPA and into faster growing, non-user based areas; (4) this remains a debated name with more bears on competition vis-a-vis growth, while bulls wonder if ZS could benefit from more agentic traffic along with more palatable valuation versus larger security peers. We think the analyst day could be modestly positive from potentially higher margins and more on the evolution of the multi-product story, but we think the slope of the growth curve here has to flatten more in order to change hearts and minds. Our price target goes to \$220 based on ~30x FY28E FCF.

- **We expect ZS to reiterate its FY27 ARR guide after news of its CRO transition, and talk about its aspiration of reaching \$10B in ARR - but at just under \$4.5B in ARR expected here in FY27, this is likely a 5+ year path.** An investor day isn't an annual event for ZS, so we expect to hear more about its mid- to long-term financial model. To start, ZS has talked about aspiring to \$10B in ARR so we expect to hear more about that path at investor day, though at ~\$4.4B in ARR expected for FY27, this target is likely happening after FY30 which may be more difficult to underwrite at this point. More near term, we think ZS could also reiterate its FY27 ARR guide of \$4,396-4,426M in light of the recent [announcement](#) that CRO Mike Rich is stepping down and Ross Tackett, former head of worldwide sales at ZS, will take his place, effective October 1. We got the question of why ZS didn't reiterate the guide on the back of this announcement, and we think it's likely because Mr. Tackett helped heavily shape this

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## Company Update

|                                      |                                                 |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| ZS                                   | <b>OVERWEIGHT</b><br>Unchanged                  |
| U.S. Software                        | <b>POSITIVE</b><br>Unchanged                    |
| Price Target                         | <b>USD 220.00</b><br>raised 10% from USD 200.00 |
| Price (25-Sep-26)                    | <b>USD 193.05</b>                               |
| Potential Upside/Downside            | <b>+14.0%</b>                                   |
| Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research |                                                 |

|                             |               |
|-----------------------------|---------------|
| Market Cap (USD mn)         | <b>31477</b>  |
| Shares Outstanding (mn)     | <b>163.05</b> |
| Free Float (%)              | <b>63.81</b>  |
| 52 Wk Avg Daily Volume (mn) | <b>2.9</b>    |
| Dividend Yield (%)          | <b>N/A</b>    |
| Return on Equity TTM (%)    | <b>-2.87</b>  |
| Current BVPS (USD)          | <b>15.94</b>  |
| Source: Bloomberg           |               |

|                   |                          |
|-------------------|--------------------------|
| Price Performance | <b>Exchange-Nasdaq</b>   |
| 52 Week range     | <b>USD 336.99-114.63</b> |



Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg  
[Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting](#)

### U.S. Software

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guide as head of WW sales and we'll likely hear more about confidence in the forecast at investor day.

- ZS could raise its LT EBIT margin target to something between 25-30% in our view as it drives leverage from multi-product sales and has favorable unit economics; this would put it in line with other leading security vendors like CRWD and PANW who are targeting high 20%'s to 30%+.** ZS has exceeded its prior long-term operating margin target of 20-22% with 23% in FY26 and 23.7% expected for FY27, so we think this target will need to be updated at investor day. We wonder if something in the range of 25-30% is a reasonable expectation over the medium term for two reasons. First, recall during its IPO, ZS showed how contribution from its 2015 cohort of customers went from (87%) in year 1 to 65% in year 2 to 68% in year 3; while we do not have an update on this, we imagine the unit economics are still similar (if not better) with largely similar retention rates, more product, and higher pricing. Second, zooming out, remember CRWD is targeting 28-32% operating margins and PANW is targeting low to mid 30%'s operating margins over the mid- to long-term; to be clear, we think there are differences in these businesses/end markets versus SASE, but all three are leading security vendors in their respective end markets so we believe a 25-30% range is achievable for ZS.
- ZS could dive deeper into how its business is diversifying outside of user-based products like ZIA/ZPA, with faster growth in non-user based products like Zero Trust Branch, Zero Trust Cloud, Data Security, and Security for AI.** Outside of the financial model, we expect ZS to talk more about two themes: how the platform is growing with Zero Trust Everywhere, Data Security, and Security for AI, and how the pricing models are evolving. On the former, we think some investors view ZS as primarily a ZIA/ZPA company where competition is growing with vendors like PANW, Netskope (NTSK, not covered), and a private pure play SASE vendor. While we believe ZIA/ZPA remains the majority of the business, we wonder if ZS could talk more about the multi-product story with areas like Zero Trust Branch, Zero Trust Cloud, Data Security, and Security for AI growing faster, which could diversify the business outside of core ZIA/ZPA and elongate the growth curve as the mix of business coming from those products gets bigger. On the latter point, with ZIA/ZPA being the core of the business historically, this pricing model has been predominately user-based. Now, with a growing mix coming from areas like Zero Trust Branch (which is based on number of devices), Zero Trust Cloud (which is based on number of workloads or traffic), Data Security (where some modules are user-based while others are volume-based), and Security for AI (which is token-based or consumption-based), we wonder if ZS could talk more about how the pricing models here are changing over time.
- Stock continues to be a debated name - more bears than bulls on competition and slope of growth curve; bulls looking for an excuse to be more constructive given more palatable valuation than bigger security names; higher margins could make analyst day modestly positive, but may not change views on competition/growth.** Zooming out on the stock, this continues to be a well debated name for several reasons. Bears see ZS as primarily a ZIA/ZPA company rather than a broader platform, and think growing competition in the zero trust/SASE market could weigh on the slope of the growth curve looking forward. Bulls are wondering if ZS could be a beneficiary of growing agentic traffic, and see a more palatable valuation than bigger security names (ZS -11% YTD versus PANW +110%, CRWD +120%, HACK +48%, and SPX +12% YTD). Zooming into the analyst day, we could see how potentially higher target margins could be modestly positive for consensus numbers, and the changing mix of the business could open up the discussion on Acts 2/3 - but we think it will take faster growth to change hearts/minds on the competitive bear case here.

**ZS: Quarterly and Annual EPS (USD)**

|        | 2026   | 2027  |       |       | 2028  |       |       | Change y/y |      |
|--------|--------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|------------|------|
| FY Jul | Actual | Old   | New   | Cons  | Old   | New   | Cons  | 2027       | 2028 |
| Q1     | 0.96A  | 1.16E | 1.16E | 1.16E | 1.30E | 1.30E | 1.32E | 21%        | 12%  |
| Q2     | 1.01A  | 1.19E | 1.19E | 1.18E | 1.33E | 1.33E | 1.35E | 18%        | 12%  |
| Q3     | 1.08A  | 1.22E | 1.22E | 1.23E | 1.37E | 1.37E | 1.42E | 13%        | 12%  |
| Q4     | 1.19A  | 1.31E | 1.31E | 1.31E | 1.46E | 1.46E | 1.51E | 10%        | 11%  |
| Year   | 4.24A  | 4.88E | 4.88E | 4.89E | 5.46E | 5.46E | 5.60E | 15%        | 12%  |
| P/E    | 45.6   |       | 39.5  |       |       | 35.4  |       |            |      |

Consensus numbers are from Bloomberg received on 28-Sep-2026; 12:50 GMT

Source: Barclays Research

## U.S. Software

POSITIVE

## Zscaler, Inc. (ZS)

OVERWEIGHT

| Income statement (\$mn)            | 2026A  | 2027E  | 2028E  | 2029E  | CAGR    |
|------------------------------------|--------|--------|--------|--------|---------|
| Revenue                            | 3,353  | 3,923  | 4,491  | 5,084  | 14.9%   |
| EBITDA (adj)                       | 916    | 1,112  | 1,306  | 1,515  | 18.3%   |
| Operating profit (adj)             | 767    | 928    | 1,087  | 1,255  | 17.8%   |
| Pre-tax income (adj)               | 891    | 1,069  | 1,230  | 1,387  | 15.9%   |
| Net income (adj)                   | 704    | 845    | 971    | 1,096  | 15.9%   |
| EPS (adj) (\$)                     | 4.24   | 4.88   | 5.46   | 6.03   | 12.5%   |
| Diluted shares (mn)                | 166.2  | 173.0  | 178.1  | 181.6  | 3.0%    |
| DPS (\$)                           | 0.00   | 0.00   | 0.00   | 0.00   | N/A     |
| Margin and return data             | 2026A  | 2027E  | 2028E  | 2029E  | Average |
| EBITDA (adj) margin (%)            | 26.0   | 26.9   | 27.5   | 28.1   | 27.1    |
| Operating margin (adj) (%)         | 22.9   | 23.7   | 24.2   | 24.7   | 23.9    |
| Pre-tax (adj) margin (%)           | 26.6   | 27.2   | 27.4   | 27.3   | 27.1    |
| Net (adj) margin (%)               | 21.0   | 21.5   | 21.6   | 21.6   | 21.4    |
| ROIC (%)                           | 29.6   | 3.4    | 7.4    | 7.1    | 11.9    |
| ROA (%)                            | 9.0    | 9.0    | 10.4   | 9.8    | 9.5     |
| ROE (%)                            | 9.0    | 9.0    | 10.4   | 9.8    | 9.5     |
| Balance sheet and cash flow (\$mn) | 2026A  | 2027E  | 2028E  | 2029E  | CAGR    |
| Net PP&E                           | 753    | 1,117  | 1,329  | 1,517  | 26.3%   |
| Goodwill                           | 1,218  | 1,218  | 1,218  | 1,218  | 0.0%    |
| Cash and equivalents               | 3,474  | 4,413  | 3,818  | 5,131  | 13.9%   |
| Total assets                       | 7,867  | 9,420  | 9,375  | 11,208 | 12.5%   |
| Short and long-term debt           | 1,696  | 1,725  | 0      | 0      | -100.0% |
| Other long-term liabilities        | 71     | 71     | 71     | 71     | 0.0%    |
| Total liabilities                  | 5,268  | 5,901  | 4,805  | 5,497  | 1.4%    |
| Net debt/(funds)                   | -1,778 | -2,688 | -3,818 | -5,131 | N/A     |
| Shareholders' equity               | 2,598  | 3,520  | 4,570  | 5,711  | 30.0%   |
| Change in working capital          | -98    | 142    | 39     | 61     | N/A     |
| Cash flow from operations          | 1,130  | 1,480  | 1,578  | 1,773  | 16.2%   |
| Capital expenditure                | -277   | -490   | -360   | -360   | N/A     |
| Free cash flow                     | 779    | 910    | 1,130  | 1,313  | 19.0%   |
| Valuation and leverage metrics     | 2026A  | 2027E  | 2028E  | 2029E  | Average |
| P/E (adj) (x)                      | 45.6   | 39.5   | 35.4   | 32.0   | 38.1    |
| EV/sales (x)                       | 9.1    | 7.7    | 6.8    | 6.0    | 7.4     |
| EV/EBITDA (adj) (x)                | 33.2   | 27.3   | 23.3   | 20.0   | 25.9    |
| Equity FCF yield (%)               | 2.4    | 2.7    | 3.3    | 3.7    | 3.0     |
| Dividend yield (%)                 | 0.0    | 0.0    | 0.0    | 0.0    | 0.0     |
| Net debt/EBITDA (adj) (x)          | -1.9   | -2.4   | -2.9   | -3.4   | -2.7    |
| Total debt/capital (%)             | 39.5   | 32.9   | 0.0    | 0.0    | 18.1    |
| Selected operating metrics (\$mn)  | 2026A  | 2027E  | 2028E  | 2029E  | CAGR    |
| License revenue                    | 3,353  | 3,923  | 4,491  | 5,084  | 14.9%   |
| Deferred revenue                   | 2,926  | 3,376  | 3,930  | 4,566  | 16.0%   |

Note: FY End Jul

Source: Company data, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

Price (25-Sep-2026) **USD 193.05**  
Price Target **USD 220.00**

**Why OVERWEIGHT?**

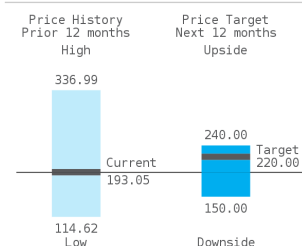
We like the secular growth in SASE and Zscaler is a leader here with first-mover and scale advantages. ZS also has a growing platform story as customers consolidate security tools, and we think these factors will drive 20%+ billings growth through FY26. Healthy top-line growth, margin expansion, and FCF support creates a favorable risk-reward in our view.

**Upside case** **USD 240.00**

Our upside case of \$240 assumes FY28 free cash flow comes in ~5% higher than our estimate, and we apply a ~31x multiple.

**Downside case** **USD 150.00**

Our downside case of \$150 assumes FY28 free cash flow comes in ~10% lower than our estimate, and we apply a ~21x multiple.

**Upside/Downside scenarios**

## Valuation

We raise our price target to \$220 based on ~30x our FY28E free cash flow estimate of ~\$1.1B as we think potentially higher target margins and a deeper dive into products outside of ZIA/ZPA coming out of the analyst day could improve investor sentiment on Acts 2/3 and support a higher multiple. Our prior price target of \$200 was based on ~27x our FY28E free cash flow estimate of ~\$1.1B.

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**Zscaler, Inc.** (ZS, 25-Sep-2026, USD 193.05), Overweight/Positive, CE/FA/J/K/M

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|                                   |                               |                              |
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| Sprout Social, Inc. (SPT)         | Tenable Holdings Inc (TENB)   | Teradata Corp. (TDC)         |
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| Veeva Systems Inc. (VEEV)         | WhiteFiber, Inc. (WYFI)       | Workday Inc. (WDAY)          |
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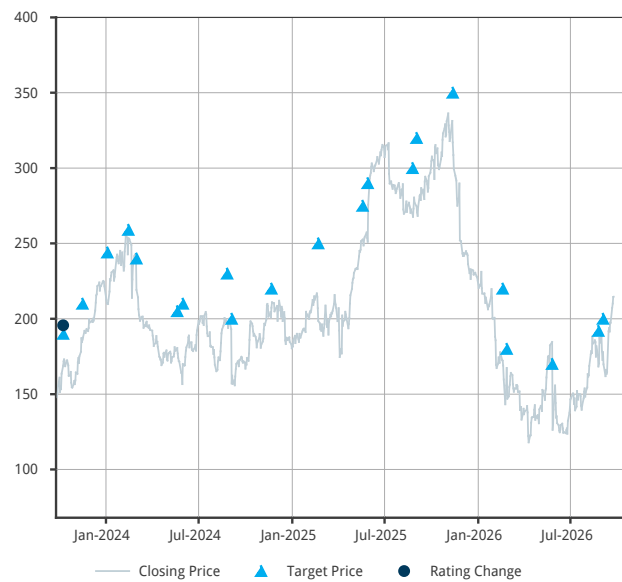
**Zscaler, Inc. (ZS / ZS)**

Stock Rating: **OVERWEIGHT**

Industry View: **POSITIVE**

Closing Price: **USD 193.05** (25-Sep-2026)

**Rating and Price Target Chart (as of 25-Sep-2026)**



Source: LSEG Data & Analytics, Bloomberg, Barclays Research

[Link to Barclays Live for interactive charting](#)

| Publication Date | Closing Price* | Rating     | Adjusted Price Target | Currency |
|------------------|----------------|------------|-----------------------|----------|
| 03-Sep-2026      | 177.80         |            | 200.00                | USD      |
| 25-Aug-2026      | 181.75         |            | 192.00                | USD      |
| 26-May-2026      | 184.60         |            | 170.00                | USD      |
| 26-Feb-2026      | 167.36         |            | 180.00                | USD      |
| 18-Feb-2026      | 172.13         |            | 220.00                | USD      |
| 12-Nov-2025      | 331.29         |            | 350.00                | USD      |
| 02-Sep-2025      | 277.05         |            | 320.00                | USD      |
| 25-Aug-2025      | 270.35         |            | 300.00                | USD      |
| 29-May-2025      | 251.11         |            | 290.00                | USD      |
| 19-May-2025      | 251.50         |            | 275.00                | USD      |
| 21-Feb-2025      | 206.97         |            | 250.00                | USD      |
| 21-Nov-2024      | 200.94         |            | 220.00                | USD      |
| 04-Sep-2024      | 193.19         |            | 200.00                | USD      |
| 26-Aug-2024      | 197.78         |            | 230.00                | USD      |
| 31-May-2024      | 156.65         |            | 210.00                | USD      |
| 20-May-2024      | 178.86         |            | 205.00                | USD      |
| 01-Mar-2024      | 241.97         |            | 240.00                | USD      |
| 14-Feb-2024      | 242.80         |            | 259.00                | USD      |
| 04-Jan-2024      | 210.24         |            | 244.00                | USD      |
| 16-Nov-2023      | 187.09         |            | 210.00                | USD      |
| 09-Oct-2023      | 153.30         | Overweight | 190.00                | USD      |

On 28-Sep-2023, prior to any intra-day change that may have been published, the rating for this security was Equal Weight, and the adjusted price target was 176.00 USD.

Source: Bloomberg, Barclays Research

\*This is the closing price referenced in the publication, which may not be the last available closing price at the time of publication.

Historical stock prices and price targets may have been adjusted for stock splits and dividends.

**CE:** Barclays Bank PLC and/or an affiliate is a market-maker in equity securities issued by Zscaler, Inc..

**FA:** Barclays Bank PLC and/or an affiliate beneficially owns 1% or more of a class of equity securities of Zscaler, Inc., as calculated in accordance with US regulations.

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**K:** Barclays Bank PLC and/or an affiliate has received non-investment banking related compensation (including compensation for brokerage services, if applicable) from Zscaler, Inc. within the past 12 months.

**M:** Zscaler, Inc. is, or during the past 12 months has been, a non-investment banking client (securities related services) of Barclays Bank PLC and/or an affiliate.

**Valuation Methodology:** Our price target of \$220 is based on ~30x our FY28E free cash flow estimate of ~\$1.1B.

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